

Instructions

Digital Archives Reflection Assignment (2026)

Due: 26 April 2026 at 11:59pm

Instructions: Please answer the following questions and upload your answers to Brightspace. The provided word counts are a guideline to help you succeed in completing this assignment. If you choose to submit this assignment in a group, note down your group members and who worked on each part of your submission. *All sources used to answer this assignment must be properly cited according to the instructions in the class syllabus.* After submission, you will receive brief feedback which you can use to improve your assignment for your final portfolio.

Part 1

Explain how Jensen's (2021) category of "digital archival literacy" addresses the distinct challenges digital archives represent for historical research. How has digitization changed historians' interactions with their sources? In your response, focus on two points that you found most thought-provoking. You may also choose to cite Jensen and Schriver (2022) in your response. (250 words)

According to Jensen, the digitization of archival materials has created a greater opportunity for historical research, that however has its own set of problems which historians today and in the future will have to solve. For one, digitalized archives are selected by individuals for the purpose of distributing them for the public to see. This creates problems like the selection of archival material to be digitized, which can be biased to show a certain narrative, or to appease what is popular in the public or make something popular. Another aspect of the selection of digital archives is who funds and finds the research. On one hand, research with high funding can be paid for by private interests that want a certain narrative. On the other hand, archival research with low funding often uses volunteers to do the research and scanning, which can lead to a digital archive comprised with documents that the public already finds relevant. A way that these archives might be displayed for the purpose of being viewed by the greater public, is with how their search possibility's function. Here searching for specific terms or sentences, is answered through a display of documents that have been put into distinct popular categories like World War II. Following this development of digitization, historians need to have the ability to critically observe collections of documents online and know how to respond to the production process by taking part in discussions on the subject and in turn make their scholarly interests matter.

Part 2

Navigate to the following page entitled "David Boder: from wire recordings to website." <https://ranke2.uni.lu/u/boder/#c-clip.en>. Familiarize yourself with the page and watch the animation "David Boder's interview collection: from analogue to digital" to learn about Boder's work and recent efforts to digitize his interviews.

- i. Navigate to <https://iit.aviaryplatform.com/collections/231> and select one of David Boder's interviews to analyze. Briefly provide the biographical details of the interviewee. After reading the "description" panel, discuss the provenance of the source. For example, what metadata is

provided by the archive, and which historical details did the archive choose to emphasize in their written summary of the recording? (250 words)

The interview “David P. Boder Interviews Charles Jean, August 21, 1946, Paris, France”, has a handful of metadata. Here the categories in the description are organized under the names such as “Subject”, “Agent”, “Type”, “Interviewee nationality” and “Interviewee gender”. From this the listener gets an idea of what historical events are discussed and who is being listened to. The commentary places heavy emphasis not so much on Charles Jean’s actions, but on his identity and affiliations with family and politics. Charles Jean was in the French resistance against fascist rule, and his story is a part of a larger group of interviews with the Kahn family and their experiences. A certain attention is also given to a sense of uncertainty in the surname of Charles Jean, giving a form of transparency with the listener. This is not to say that his actions are not discussed, but the emphasis on identity is clear. By having this focus, the interview is portrayed in a more personal way, to where the person is at the center. This also goes hand in hand with Boder’s aspirations to shift the focus from grand historical events to a more small-scale individual account of how these events had affected the interviewee. By this the listener is made to entirely focus on the individual and learning from their personal experiences. However, details of Charles Jean and his role in the resistance and relationships are not written down and will have to be listened to in the recording itself.

- ii. Listen to a few minutes of your chosen interview. Focus on the intonations and emotions expressed by Boder and the interviewee (it’s okay if you do not understand German or Russian). Based on a close listening of the speakers, contemplate how such digitized interviews might provide information absent from text-based interview transcriptions. What are the implications of using interview recordings as a historical source? You may choose to draw on Presner (2024) or information from the Ranke.2 website in your response. (250 words)

The listener gets a more personal and humanizing description of the personal account of Charles Jean. Here certain aspects that are not immediately obvious is the dialogue between Madam Khan and Charles Jean, as Khan is translating Boder’s questions. When reading the transcript, it is not clear how fast Charles Jean gave an answer or reacted to the question, but when listening to it, it’s clear he eagerly wanted to tell his story as he immediately when questioned gives a long and thorough answer. By this, the listening experience gives a more humanizing and personal impression. The implication of using interview recordings as historical sources is that while it only gives an individual account of certain events with no grand explanation and context, it still emphasizes the human aspect and can even validate and legitimize historical convictions. The humanizing aspect is important, as stressed by Presner in his text “Technologies of Testimony and Distant Witnessing”, from 2024. Here Presner talks about the need to emphasize and thoroughly describe the personal stories of survivors, and the need to ethically integrate their testimony into the digital world.¹

Presner stresses the importance of this humanization through digital usage, as it’s a lesson from the past where in which technology and bureaucracy were apathetically used to partake

¹ Presner, *Technologies of Testimony and Distant Witnessing* (2024), 13.

in crimes rather than help solve it. Therefore, the usage of historical recordings is essential for understanding not just history of the Second World War, but history itself.

Part 3

Compare and contrast the use of digitized historical sources in web-based databases with reborn digital sources in the archived Web. Should these sources be treated differently when conducting historical research? To complete this task, draw on your knowledge of at least two database collections discussed in class and/or your readings. In your response, please support your position using relevant literature from our course, such as Kelley (2019), Johnson (2018), Brügger (2019), and the articles mentioned in part one of this assignment. (500 words)

Digitized historical sources and reborn digital sources share a lot of similarities. With concrete examples, and lengthy description, both types of databases have great value in historical research. How they exactly do that is different as they have different values depending on what the historian is researching. As stated by Brügger in his article “Understanding the archived web as a historical source” from 2019, each database should be interacted with differently and therefore can’t have the same method of research applied.²

An example of this could be research of African history, where a database like “Slave voyages” would be preferable. This being a digitized database means that the archival material is being taken from historical documents, in which the historian has a clear and detailed collection of data where the subject can be studied. Using a reborn digital source from a database like the wayback machine could in theory also be used, however where a database like this might fall short is the potential outdated web crawling that might be on the relevant sites needed. Therefore, in this instance, the digitized archives would be a better and more consistent tool. However, where digitized archives are more useful for work in specific subjects, the reborn databases like the way back machine are more flexible, as it able to show the historian a great amount of data from its up to a trillion different web pages. This could be more useful in research looking to find out how the internet was built up at a certain point in time. Staying on the subject of African history, this flexibility of historical data could be used to create a more grand and extensive research on the history and experiences of African Americans. This creates more humanization which is what Johnson in her text “Markup Bodies Black [Life] Studies and Slavery [Death] Studies at the Digital Crossroads” from 2018 says the research needs. In the text Johnson describes how historical research on slavery has fallen into similar kinds of overviews of statistics and numbers which does not do justice to the suffering of millions of Africans.³ She argues for a more humane and introspective path for which, African American history is treated.⁴ Here the wayback machine would be a preferable tool to be used, as by using it the historian can look through hundreds if not many more webpages discussing the subject. It is this flexibility that makes it so more focus can be put on different aspects of modern history. Overall, both databases can be used together for greater and more thorough research, but they differ in flexibility and consistency and therefore will need different methods when used.

² Niels Brügger, “DIGITAL HISTORIE OG ARKIVERET WEB SOM HISTORISK KILDE”, *Temp - tidsskrift for historie* 7, nr. 14 (2017/2019): 3.

³ Jessica Johnson, *Markup Bodies Black [Life] Studies and Slavery [Death] Studies at the Digital Crossroad*, 2018 (u.å.): 64–65.

⁴ Jessica Johnson, *Markup Bodies Black [Life] Studies and Slavery [Death] Studies at the Digital Crossroad*, (2018): 66.